

Not truly open: On tennis and the U.S. Open

Tennis needs a strong middle tier to see **keen** contests through two weeks

Sport is at its best when there is a clearly **established pecking order** and **intense** competition between the **hierarchical rungs**. The **presence** of a **dominant** and **diverse** set at the top, followed by a capable and **efficient** mid-card, and an under-card that can **upset the apple cart** **makes** for engaging viewing. However, in recent times, the men's and women's tennis tours have seen **a hollowing out** of the middle. It is particularly **stark** in the men's game where Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner have **pocketed** the last seven Grand Slam tournaments, talents as **effervescent** as 2021 U.S. Open winner Daniil Medvedev are threatening to **fade away** while teenaged **phenoms** such as Joao Fonseca are rising. At the ongoing U.S. Open, it will be interesting to see if a class that **consistently snaps at the heels of the top dogs** **emerges**. The **legendary Novak Djokovic**, winner of a record 24 men's Slams, **has** made three semifinals in as many Majors in 2025. The 38-year-old is still good, but the question is if he is good enough to go all the way. **Taylor Fritz and Ben Shelton**, No. 4 and No. 6 respectively, **are** out to end the United States of America's 22-year wait for a male Slam winner even as Alexander Zverev will be **desperate** to prove that his No. 3 ranking is not an **anomaly**.

Among women, Aryna Sabalenka, Iga Swiatek and Coco Gauff have combined to win 10 of the last 14 Majors. Though the **trio's** hold at the top is not as **water-tight** as the Alcaraz-Sinner **duopoly**, they are the players to beat. **World No. 1 Sabalenka**, a finalist this year at both the Australian Open and the French Open and a semifinalist at Wimbledon, **will** be **eager** to defend her title at **Flushing Meadows** and avoid a Major-less season. **Swiatek**, who **resurrected** her career at the All England Club in July after a year-long **slump**, **has** continued her fine touch, winning a key U.S. Open **tune-up event** in Cincinnati. Gauff has had a forgettable time since **securing** the **Roland-Garros** crown but the home setting in New York should **energise** her. It will be **intriguing** to watch who among Jessica Pegula (2024 U.S. Open runner-up), Jasmine Paolini, Amanda Anisimova, Elena Rybakina — the 2022 Wimbledon champion — and Emma Navarro **turn out to be** the challengers. Also of interest will be 18-year-old **sensation** Mirra Andrejeva. The Russian won Dubai and Indian Wells, **broke into** the top-10, made back-to-back quarterfinals at the French Open and Wimbledon, and is now World No. 5. **The cream has risen to the top**. Will it stay there?

[Practice Exercise]

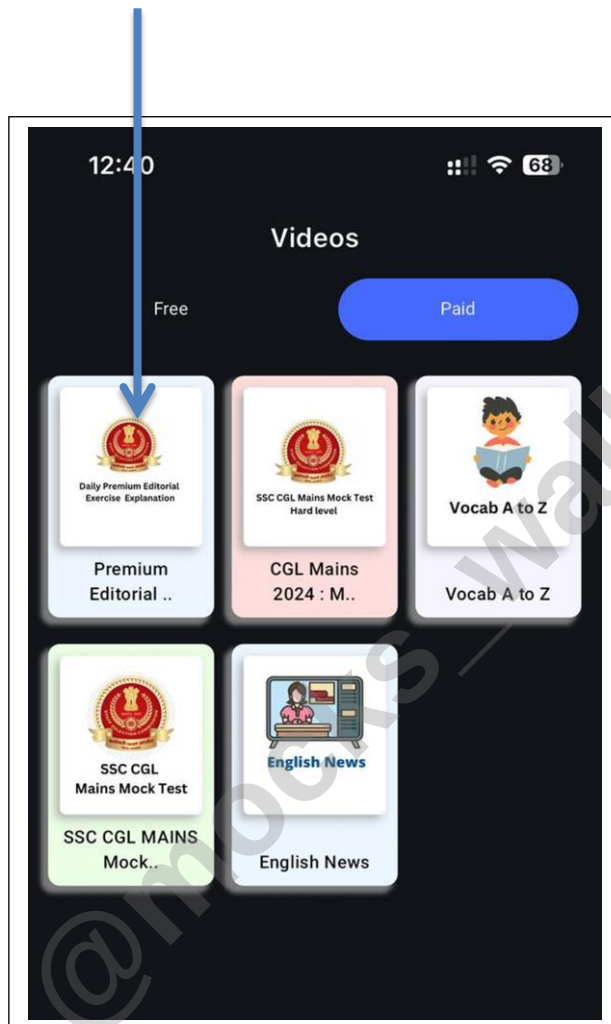
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Keen** (adjective) – intense, fierce, spirited, close-fought, hard-contested कड़ा
2. **Established** (adjective) – entrenched, settled, recognized, proven, well-set स्थापित
3. **Pecking order** (noun) – hierarchy, ranking, order of precedence, chain of command, power ladder पदानुक्रम
4. **Intense** (adjective) – fierce, high-octane, heated, taut, high-stakes तीव्र
5. **Hierarchical** (adjective) – tiered, stratified, ranked, layered, ordered पदानुक्रमीय
6. **Rung** (noun) – tier, level, step, stratum, echelon पायदान
7. **Dominant** (adjective) – leading, prevailing, commanding, pre-eminent, supreme प्रमुख
8. **Diverse** (adjective) – varied, assorted, heterogeneous, mixed, multifarious विविध
9. **Efficient** (adjective) – effective, competent, streamlined, well-drilled, slick कुशल
10. **Upset the apple cart** (phrase) – derail plans, cause an upset, rock the boat, spoil the script, throw a wrench खेल बिगाड़ना
11. **A hollowing out** (phrase) – depletion, thinning, erosion, attrition, drain क्षरण
12. **Stark** (adjective) – glaring, clear-cut, blunt, severe, unmistakable स्पष्ट
13. **Pocket** (verb) – win, bag, clinch, capture, secure हासिल करना
14. **Effervescent** (adjective) – lively, sparkling, exuberant, bubbly, vivacious ऊर्जस्वी
15. **Fade away** (phrasal verb) – wane, decline, peter out, diminish, taper off मंद पड़ना
16. **Phenom** (noun) – prodigy, sensation, wunderkind, standout, rising star उदीयमान
17. **Consistently** (adverb) – steadily, reliably, persistently, regularly, invariably लगातार
18. **Snap** (verb) – harry, nip, press, hassle, hound चुनौती देना
19. **At the heels of** (phrase) – close behind, in pursuit of, on the heels of, tailing, shadowing पीछे-पीछे
20. **Dog** (noun) – leader, bigwig, front-runner, top gun, elite शीर्ष खिलाड़ी
21. **Emerge** (verb) – arise, surface, appear, materialise, break through उभरना
22. **Legendary** (adjective) – iconic, storied, fabled, celebrated, renowned दिग्गज
23. **Desperate** (adjective) – eager, driven, anxious, frantic, determined बेताब
24. **Anomaly** (noun) – outlier, aberration, exception, irregularity, oddity विसंगति

25. **Tri(o)** (noun) – trio, triad, triumvirate, threesome, trinity त्रयी
26. **Water-tight** (adjective) – airtight, unassailable, impregnable, solid, foolproof अभेद्य
27. **Duopoly** (noun) – twin dominance, two-horse rule, dual monopoly, double hegemony, two-party control द्विधिकार
28. **Eager** (adjective) – keen, enthusiastic, ardent, zealous, hungry उत्सुक
29. **Flushing Meadows** (noun) – venue of the US Open in New York न्यूयॉर्क का यूएस ओपन परिसर
30. **Resurrect** (verb) – revive, rekindle, restore, rejuvenate, reinvigorate पुनर्जीवित करना
31. **Slump** (noun) – downturn, dip, rut, drought, slide मंदी
32. **Tune-up event** (noun) – a process of making small adjustments to something to improve its performance or condition तैयारी टूर्नामेंट
33. **Secure** (verb) – clinch, obtain, lock down, capture, bag हासिल करना
34. **Roland-Garros** (noun) – the French Open tennis tournament in Paris फ्रेंच ओपन
35. **Energise** (verb) – galvanise, spur, invigorate, animate, pep up ऊर्जा देना
36. **Intrigue** (verb) – interest, fascinate, captivate, engross, pique रोमांचित करना
37. **Turn out to be** (phrase) – prove to be, end up being, emerge as, pan out as, reveal itself as सिद्ध होना
38. **Sensation** (noun) – phenom, marvel, wonder, breakout star, headline-maker सनसनी
39. **Break into** (phrasal verb) – enter, crack, penetrate, debut in, make inroads into प्रवेश करना
40. **The cream rises to the top** (phrase) – best prevails, quality shines, merit wins out, top talent emerges, class tells सर्वश्रेष्ठ ऊपर आता है

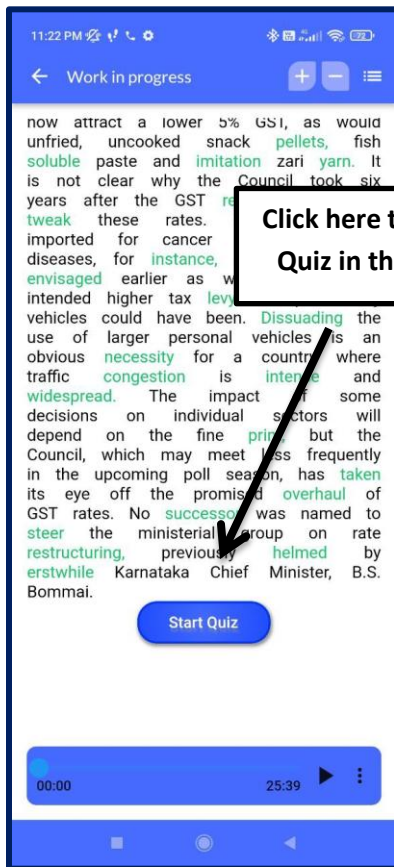
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



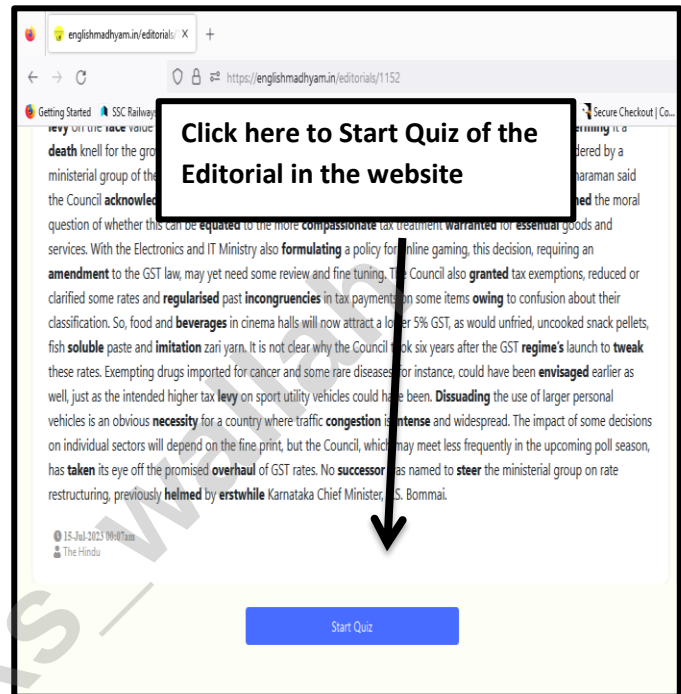
Summary of the Editorial

1. Tennis thrives when there is a strong hierarchy — top players, a competitive middle tier, and underdogs capable of surprises.
2. Recently, both men's and women's tours have witnessed a weakening of the middle tier.
3. In men's tennis, Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner have dominated, winning the last seven Grand Slams.
4. Daniil Medvedev, once a top challenger, is struggling to maintain his form.
5. Young talents such as Joao Fonseca are beginning to rise on the men's circuit.
6. Novak Djokovic, at 38, remains competitive, reaching three semifinals in 2025, but doubts persist about his ability to win big titles again.
7. American hopes rest on Taylor Fritz (World No. 4) and Ben Shelton (World No. 6) to end the 22-year U.S. Slam drought.
8. Alexander Zverev (World No. 3) is eager to justify his high ranking with strong results.
9. In women's tennis, Aryna Sabalenka, Iga Swiatek, and Coco Gauff have won 10 of the last 14 Grand Slams.
10. Sabalenka, despite reaching finals and semifinals this season, seeks to defend her U.S. Open title to avoid a Slam-less year.
11. Swiatek, after recovering from a slump, regained form by winning Wimbledon and a key U.S. Open warm-up in Cincinnati.
12. Gauff, though struggling after her French Open triumph, may find inspiration from the home crowd in New York.
13. Other possible challengers include Jessica Pegula, Jasmine Paolini, Amanda Anisimova, Elena Rybakina, and Emma Navarro.
14. Rising star Mirra Andrejeva (18), already World No. 5, has impressed with major titles, quarterfinal appearances, and top-10 breakthrough.
15. While the top players remain dominant, the key question is whether challengers can break through to ensure a truly open competition.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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